What is a Focus Group?

A Focus Group Discussion (FGD) is a small group discussion that is carefully guided by a trained leader. This isn't just a casual chat; it is a structured method used to learn about opinions on a specific designated topic to help guide future actions.

These groups usually involve 6 to 10 (or sometimes 7 to 12) participants. The goal is to capture their personal experiences and views regarding specific issues that are closely related to the researcher's questions.

Unlike a survey that counts votes, an FGD is a qualitative approach designed to gain an in-depth understanding of social issues. It aims to get data from a purposely selected group of individuals rather than a massive, general population.

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The Purpose of FGD

The primary purpose of an FGD is capturing the lived experiences and views of participants regarding specific issues. The researcher uses these discussions to uncover the ‘why’ and ‘how’ behind human behavior, which simple surveys often miss.

This data collection method is most suitable for studies where multiple perspectives are needed on the same problem. It allows the researcher to see a single issue through several different lenses simultaneously.

FGDs are frequently used to gain an in-depth understanding of social issues. By listening to people speak in their own words, researchers can obtain data that is far more nuanced than a simple “yes” or “no” answer.

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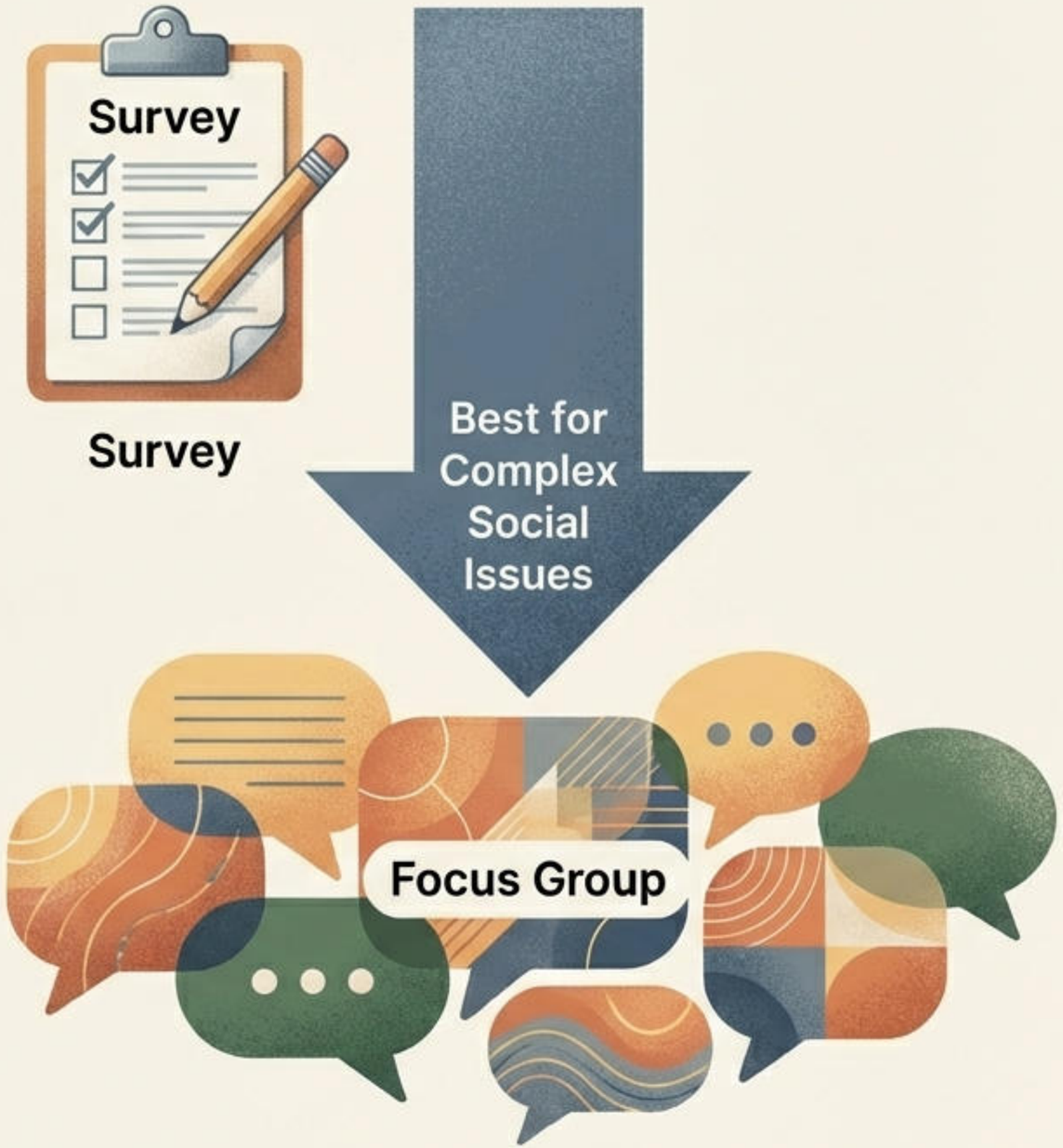
When to Use FGD

You should use a Focus Group when you need to understand the ‘why’ behind the numbers. It is the best tool when you need multiple perspectives regarding the same problem to be voiced in a shared space.

They are crucial in product and service launches. If you are launching a new product, you use this to gather feedback on concepts, features, and branding before spending money on mass production.

It is ideal for exploring social issues, such as the impact of a social program, or understanding a target audience's understanding a target audience's behavior, attitudes, and decision-making patterns.



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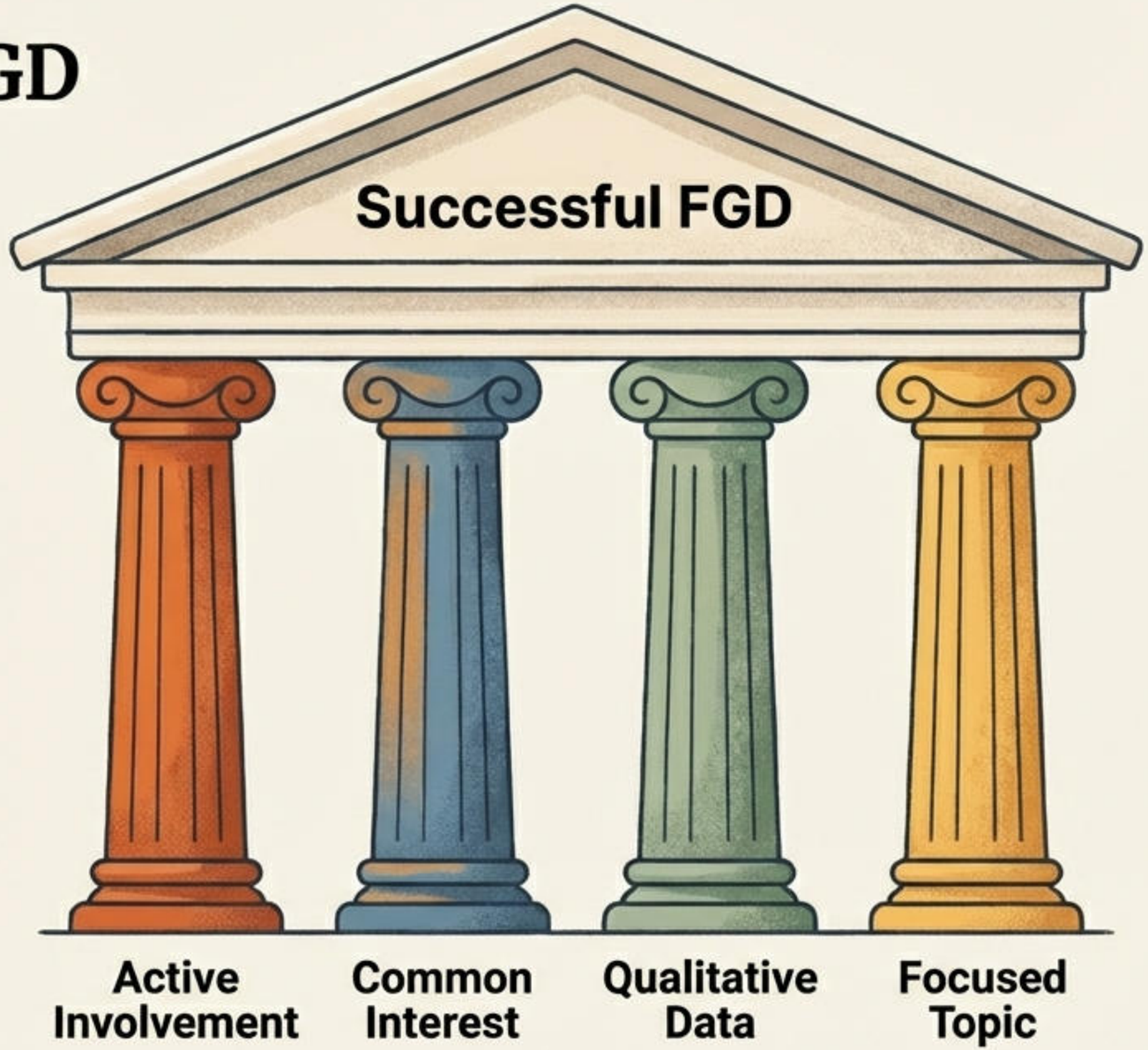
Key Characteristics of FGD

First, they must actively involve people. The participants are not passive listeners; they are the engine of the discussion.

Second, the people attending must have an experience or interest in common. There must be a shared thread that ties the room together. Third, the output must be in-depth qualitative data—rich descriptions, not just statistics.

Finally, the discussion must be focused. While conversation can flow freely, it must ultimately help the researcher understand the central idea of the topic.



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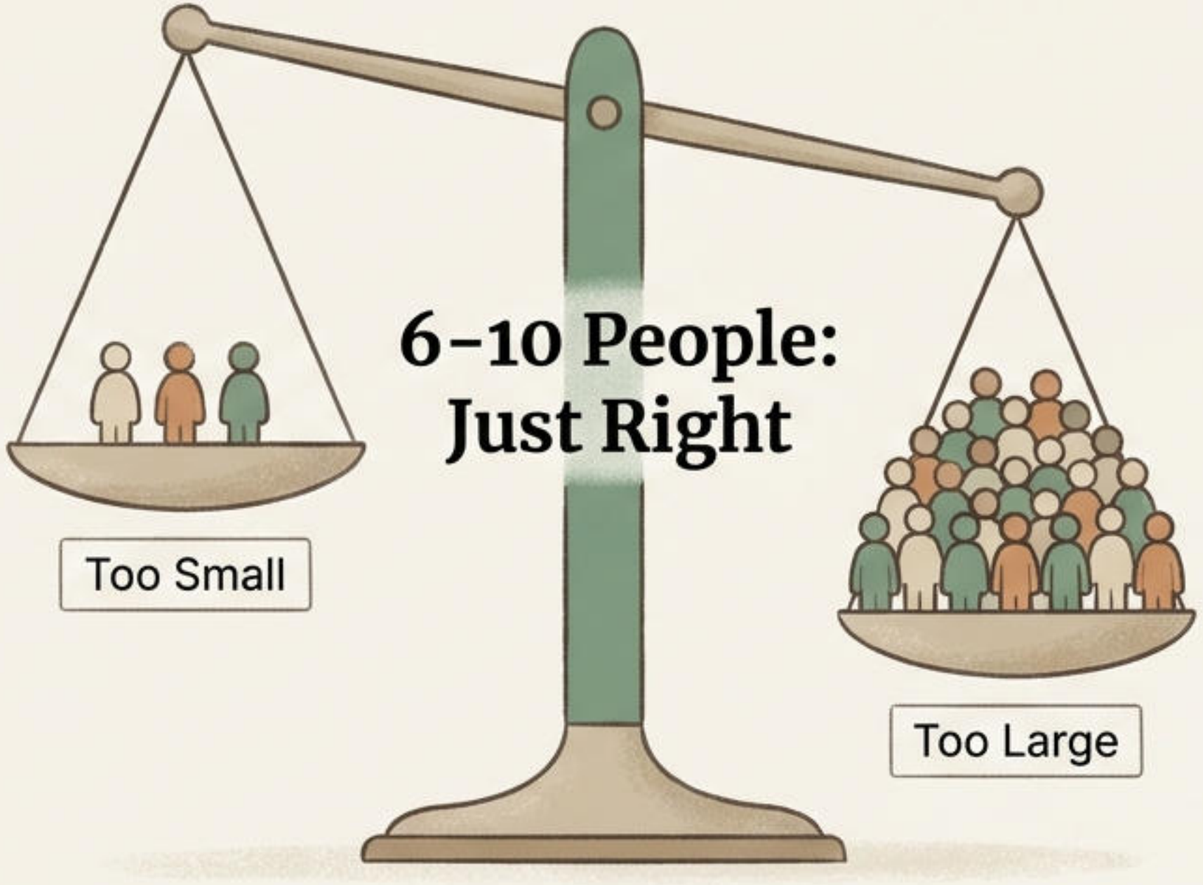
The “Goldilocks” Group Size

The ideal size is typically 6 to 10 people. This specific range is chosen for a very practical reason—it balances volume with intimacy.

If the group is smaller than 6, the pool of ideas may be limited. There isn’t enough diversity of experience to spark a truly dynamic debate.

If the group is too large, it inhibits discussion. In a crowd, some respondents will feel shy about venturing their opinions, and the logistics of managing the conversation become too difficult for the leader.



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Commonality and Recruitment

We use the concept of “Homogeneity.” In everyday language, this simply means “people having things in common or being similar to one another.”

This similarity is the basis for recruitment. Specific requirements are usually necessary for attendance. Researchers and clients must jointly identify the key criteria that identify the right individuals. You cannot just pull random people off the street.

For example, if a focus group is examining people's attitudes toward websites, the recruitment criteria would almost certainly require the participants to have access to the internet and use it fairly regularly. Without this shared experience, their opinions would not be relevant.

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Qualitative Depth

FGDs deliver data that is rich in words and descriptions rather than numbers. We are looking for the story, not the statistic.

The researcher guiding the group uses their skills to **“flush out”** ideas, attitudes, and experiences. They dig deeper than a surface-level question to get to the real feelings.

This is not just a survey read aloud. The value comes from the descriptive nuances—the adjectives and emotions people use to describe their reality.

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The Interaction Factor

A Focus Group is more than just a group interview. In an interview, the interaction is between the researcher and the participant. In an FGD, the magic happens elsewhere.

The key is the interaction between the group members. We want them to talk to each other, not just to the leader.

When participants debate, agree, or challenge each other, they reveal deeper truths than they would in a one-on-one setting. This ‘spark’ of peer-to-peer interaction is the unique value of the method.

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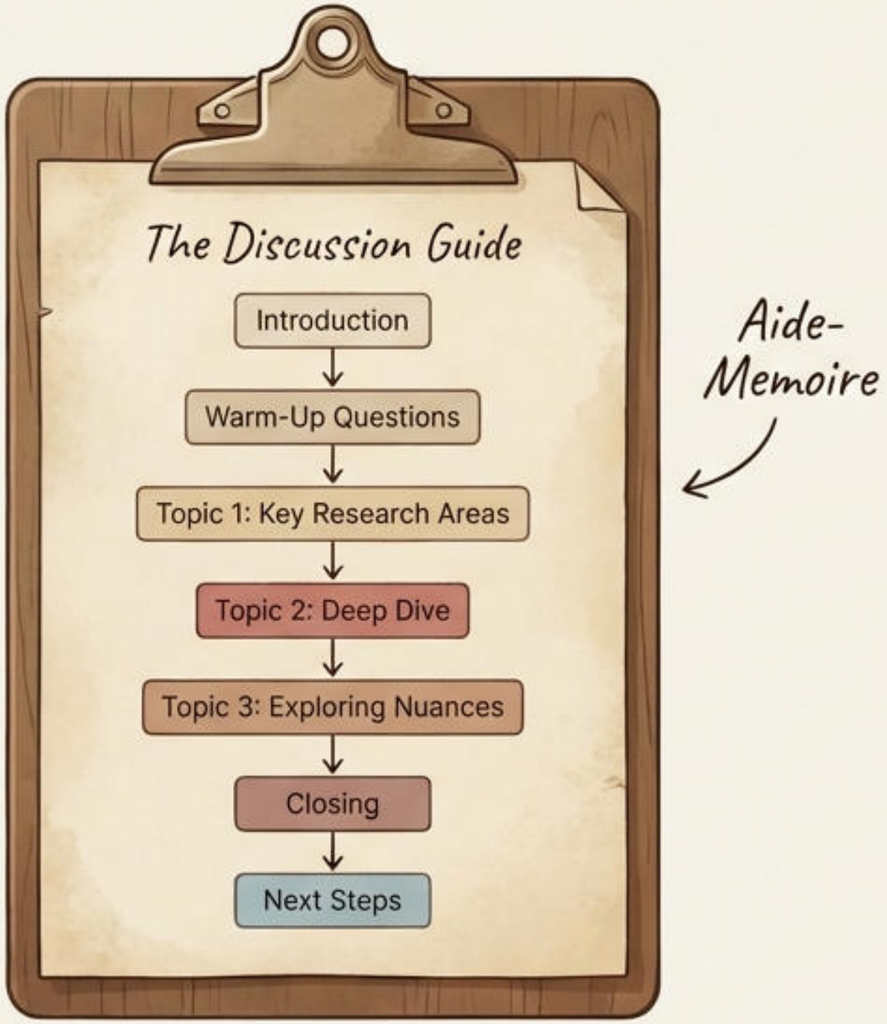
The Discussion Guide

The “Discussion Guide” is a document prepared prior to the group meeting. It serves as an aide-memoire for the moderator.

“Aide-memoire” is simply a fancy term for a helpful cheat sheet or summary to remember key points. It outlines exactly what must be covered during the session so the moderator doesn’t forget anything important.

Careful design of the guide ensures the conversation flows logically from one topic to the next, keeping a clear focus on the central research questions without getting lost in unrelated tangents.



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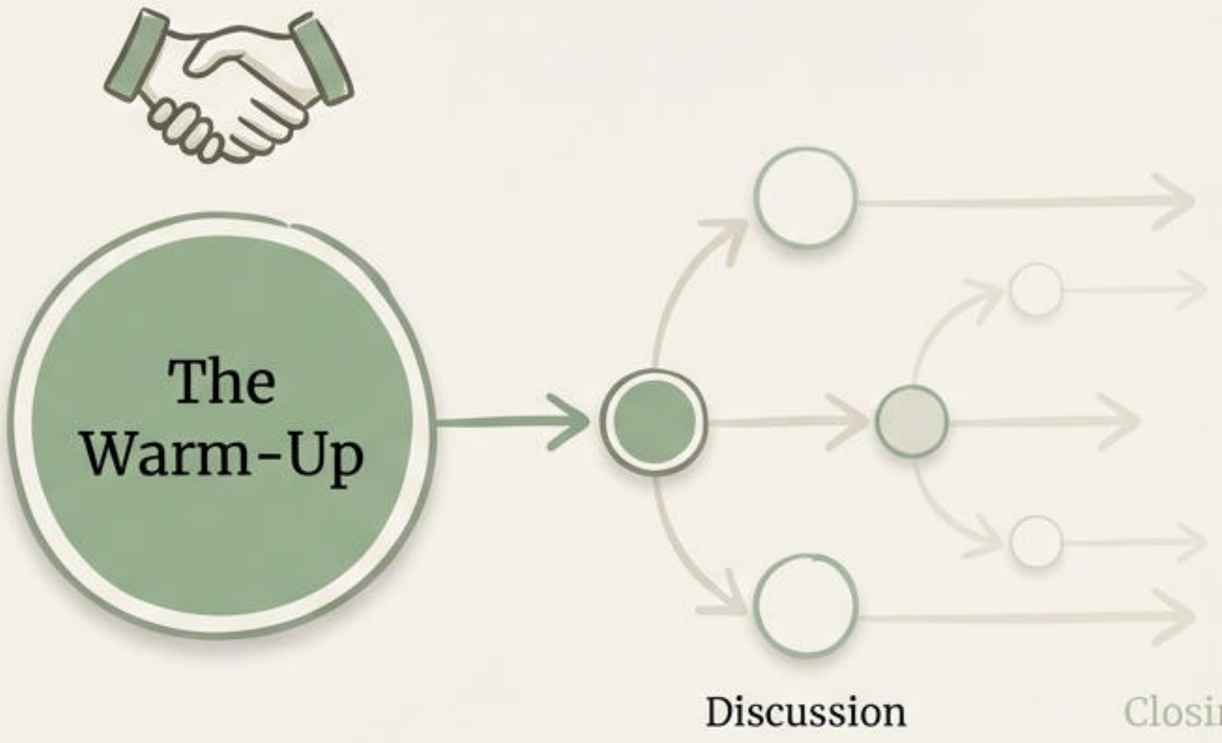
How a Session Starts

Groups always start with an introduction from the moderator explaining the purpose of the meeting and what can be expected to happen. This sets the ground rules.

Then, each person is asked to introduce themselves and perhaps say a few words about their experience with the subject.

This ‘warm-up’ serves to get people talking and feeling comfortable enough to develop their opinions. If they don’t feel safe and relaxed in the first few minutes, they won’t share their true thoughts later.



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The Flow of Debate

Questions are “thrown” to the group by the moderator. Unlike a test, these questions are open invitations for discussion.

People are encouraged to comment, debate, and adjust their views based on what others say. The goal is to cover the subject from all angles.
Points of dispute are welcomed, not silenced. The group attempts to reconcile these disputes as far as possible, and the moderator observes how these different views clash and resolve.

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Blending Qual and Quant

While FGD is qualitative, it helps explain quantitative data. Sometimes, the group itself provides both.

For example, in an HIV/AIDS study, you might find that 20% of participants did not like how HIV-positive people were portrayed in the media. That percentage is Quantitative data. The focus group then then reveals the Qualitative data reasons behind that number: they found the portrayal “demeaning,” “insensitive,” or felt that people were treated as “others.” The FGD gives the reasons for the statistic.

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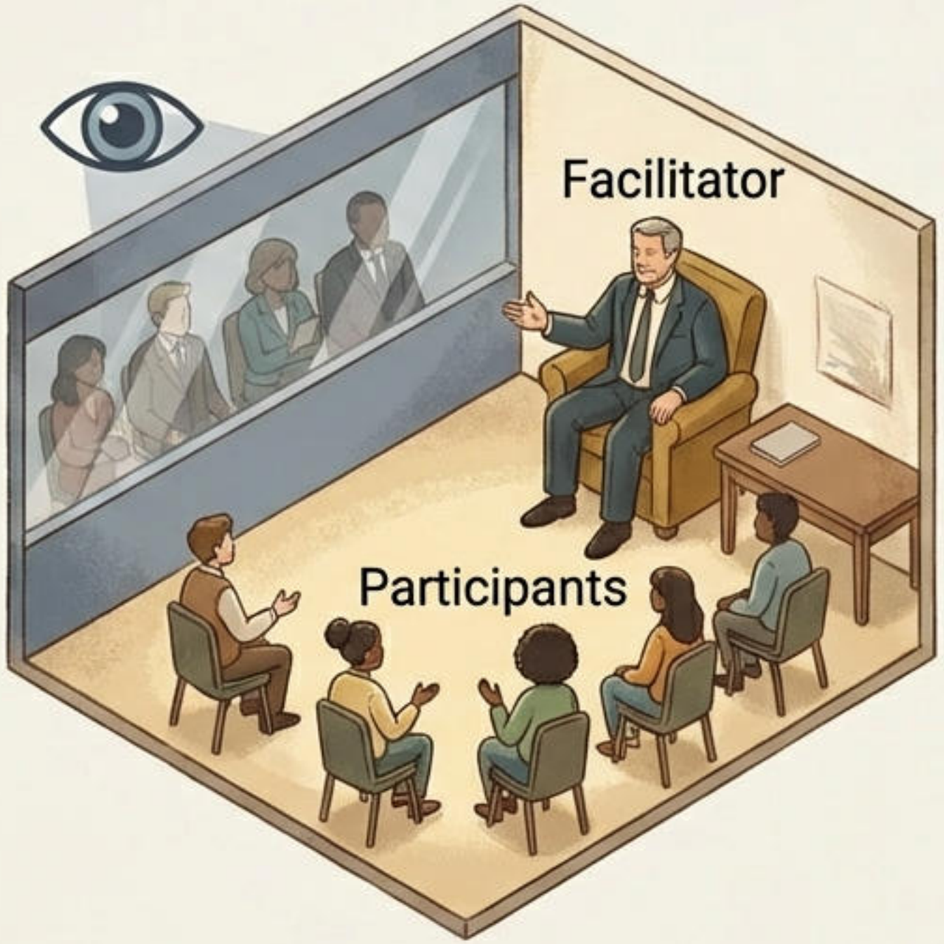
Power Dynamics and Ethics

The facilitator holds an immense amount of power in the discussion. Students must be aware of how their presence affects the answers.

Consider gender dynamics: If a male facilitator questions young girls about sexuality, will that affect the results? Almost certainly. The dynamic between who asks and who answers matters.

Sometimes, special rooms with one-way glass are used so clients (like government officials) can observe unobtrusively. However, some researchers ban clients from the room to protect the safe space.



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Practical Logistics

Because FGDs are hard to arrange, researchers often find an intermediary (an organization or individual in close contact with the community) to help recruit trust.

You need to find out if it is normal to pay participants and what the going rate is. This is a standard ethical practice.

Participants often come from poorer communities where their time is financially critical. If it is not normal to pay them in that context, the researcher may want to consider doing it anyway to set a positive trend and respect their time.

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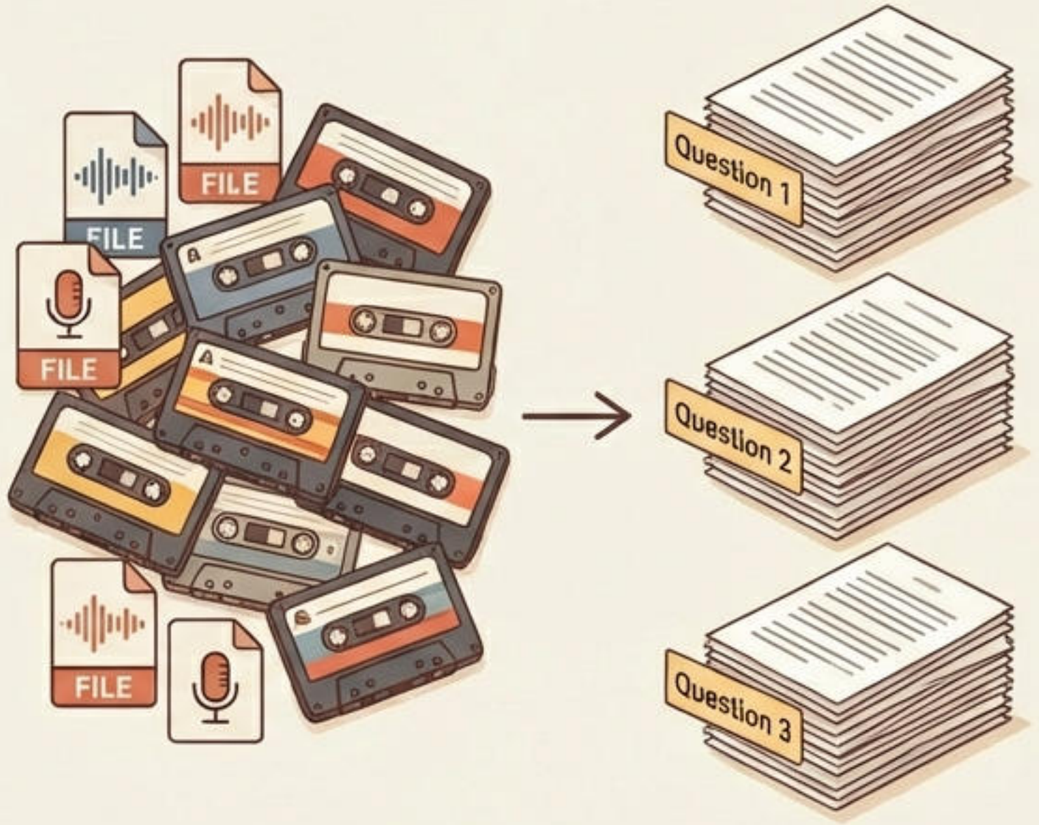
Preparing for Analysis

Step one is Transcription. You must transcribe all the focus group comments word-for-word. You cannot analyze what you haven't written down.

Step two is Rearrangement. If you do more than one group, rearrange the comments so that you have all the answers for "Question 1" together, all answers for "Question 2" together, and so on.

Step three is Identification. For each question, note the main ideas that occur. You are looking for recurring main ideas that pop up again and again across different participants.



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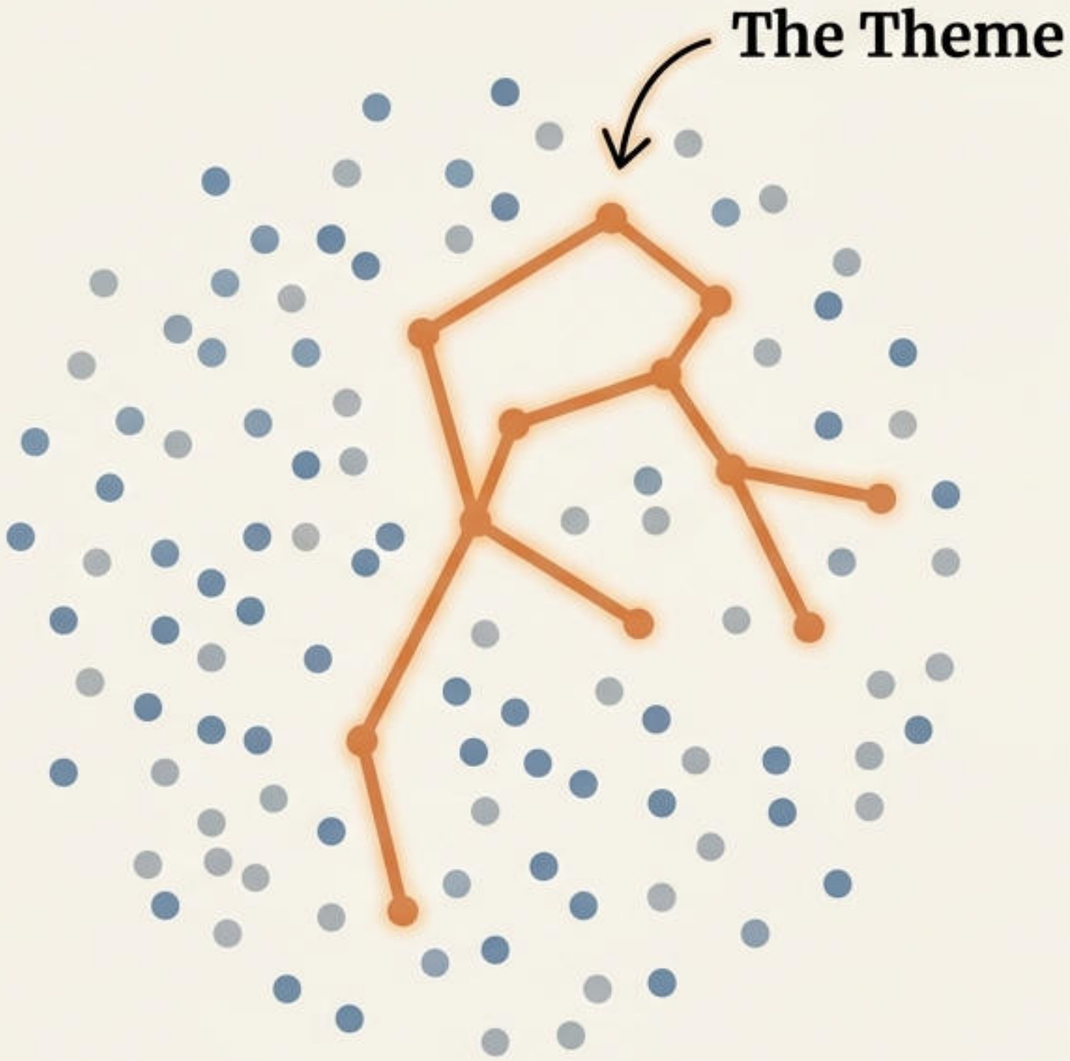
Introduction to Thematic Analysis

Thematic Analysis is a method that involves reading through a data set (like your transcripts) and identifying “patterns in meaning” across the data.

We aren’t just summarizing what people said; we are looking for the bigger picture concepts—or themes—that tie the individual comments together.

This requires judgment and care. Skepticism about focus groups often comes from the fear that this interpretation is too subjective. However, when done with care, it is a rigorous scientific approach.



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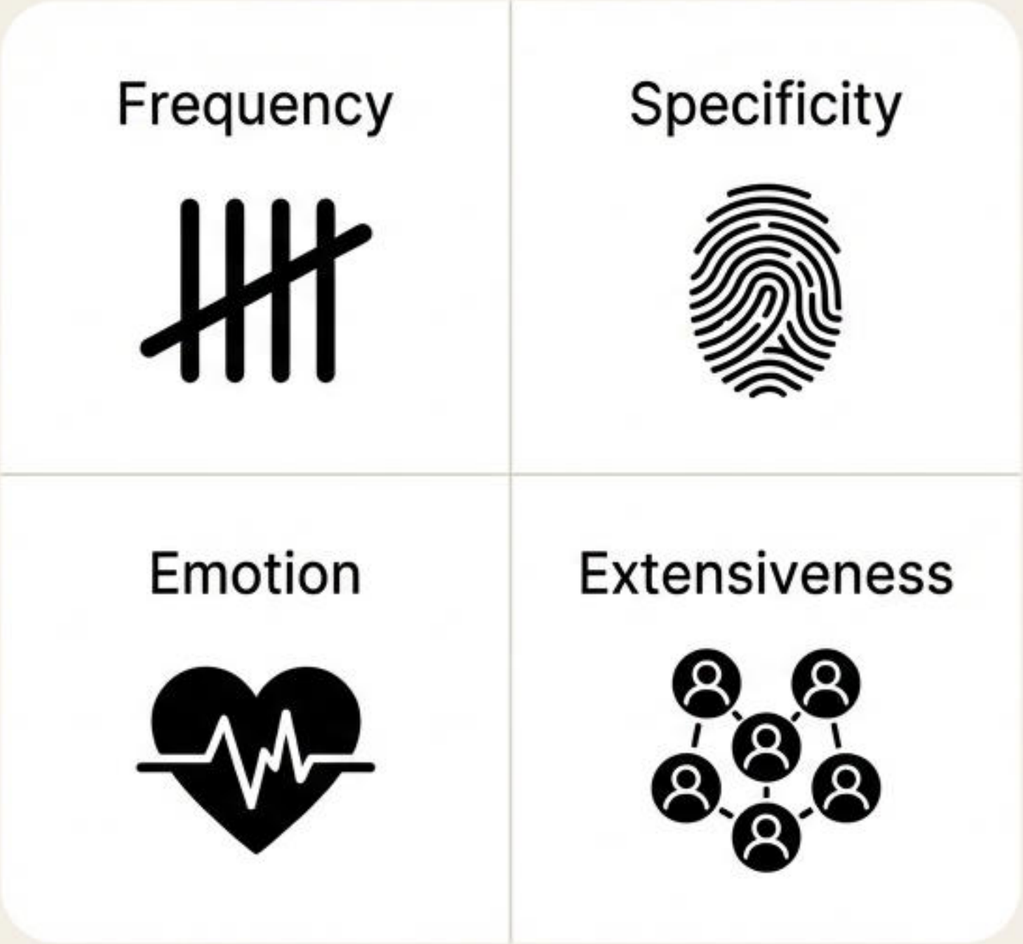
The Four Coding Factors

Frequency: How many times was something mentioned? If it comes up often, it is likely important.

Specificity & Emotion: Look for details. Detailed stories often carry more weight and truth than vague generalities. Look for enthusiasm or passion in the responses; high emotion signals a high-priority issue.

Extensiveness: How many different people said it? If only one person said it 10 times, it's less of a theme than if 10 people said it once.



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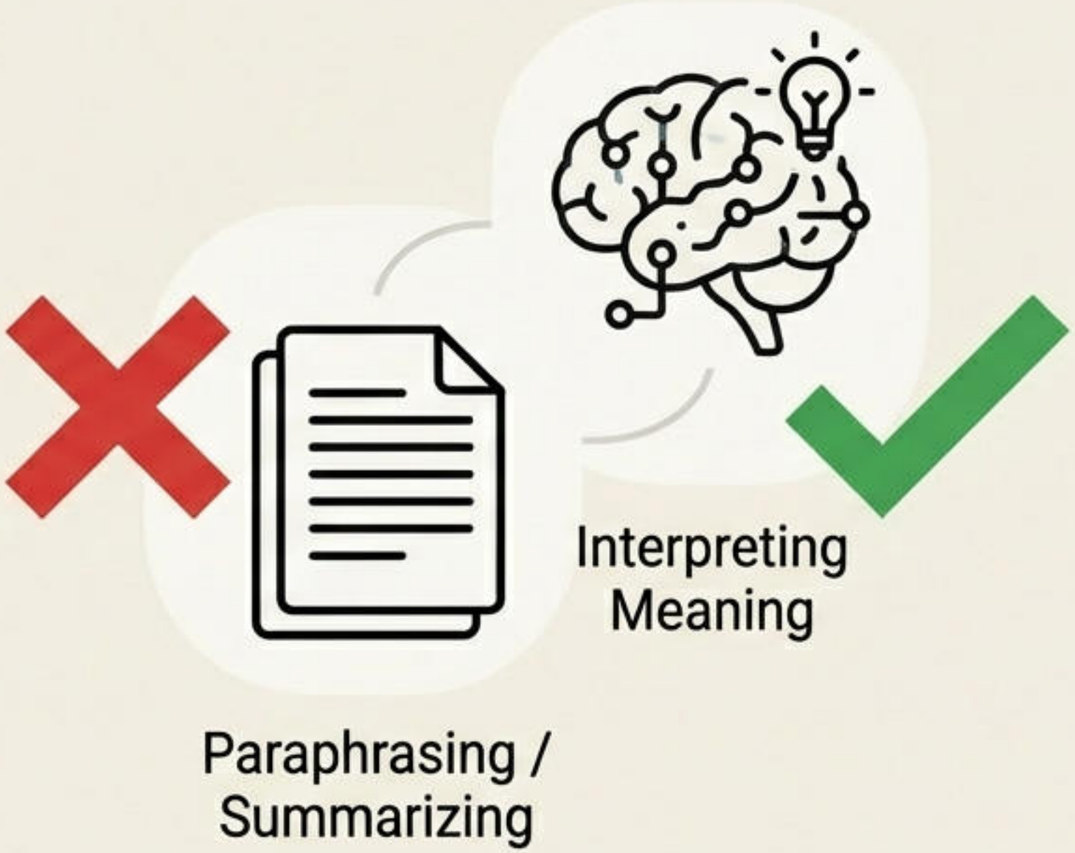
Tips for Great Analysis

Inter**pret,** don’t just paraphrase. It is easy to get stuck in a loop of just summarizing what people said. You must use your "interpretive lens" to explain what the data *means*.

Themes come from Data, not Questions. Don’t structure your analysis just by listing your interview questions. You must actively find patterns that emerge from the answers themselves.

Ensure Convincing Data. There isn’t a specific number of quotes needed to prove a theme, but you must be able to make a convincing case. Ensure your narrative is backed by the themes, and the themes are backed by the data.



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Pros and Cons of FGD

Pros

Advantages: FGDs are excellent for "grassroots input." They are helpful in developing ideas and sharing "latent" (hidden) knowledge spontaneously that a researcher might never think to ask about in a survey.

Cons

Disadvantages: They can be difficult to set up and organize. You need to find a place, get people there, and often pay them.
Sensitivity: The data is very sensitive to who the facilitator is. Also, phenomena that occur in only one individual account can be overlooked because we are so focused on finding group patterns.

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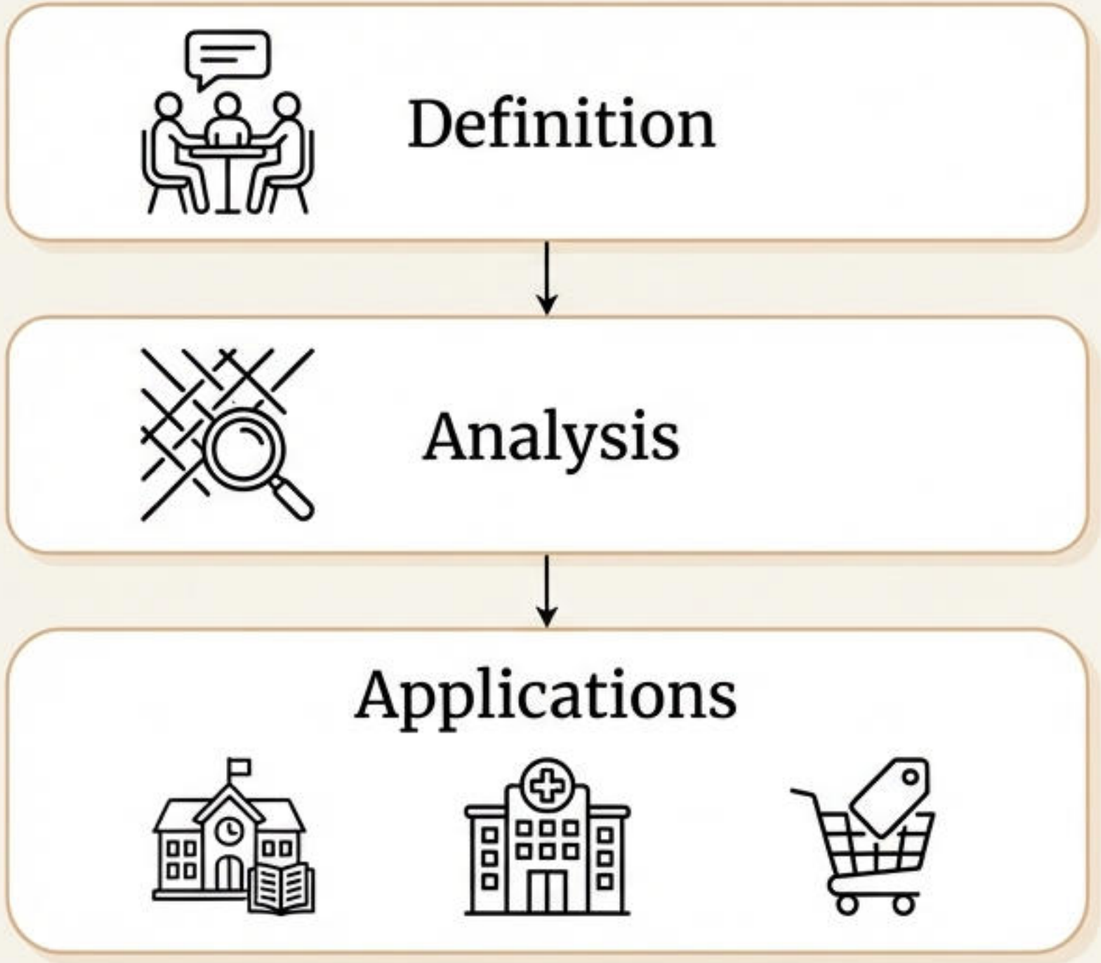
Summary for Exam Revision

Recap: A Focus Group is a small, homogeneous group (6-10 people) guided by a moderator to generate rich qualitative data through interaction. We analyze this data by looking for patterns (Thematic Analysis).

Application - Education: Used to get insights into student experiences to improve curriculum, or to collect feedback from teachers and parents on school policies.

Application - Healthcare & Market Research: Used to gather patient feedback on care delivery. In business, marketers use it to understand consumer likes and dislikes before a launch.



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